

TAB 20



Board of Education Report

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Dr. McKenna - Celebration of Black History Month 2024 (Res-019-23/24) (For Action February 13, 2024)

Whereas, Black History Month, or National African American History Month, is an annual celebration of achievements by Black Americans and a time for recognizing the central role of African Americans in United States history;

Whereas, Dr. Carter G. Woodson, a Harvard trained historian, like W.E.B. DuBois before him, believed that truth would not be denied and that reason would prevail over prejudice, and as a result announced “Negro History Week” in 1925 to raise awareness of the contributions of African Americans;

Whereas, It is commonly stated that Dr. Carter G. Woodson selected February as the month to host “Negro History Week” because it encompasses the birthdays of two great Americans who played a prominent role in shaping black history, namely Abraham Lincoln and Frederick Douglass, whose birthdays are February 12th and 14th respectively;

Whereas, Dr. Carter G. Woodson envisioned the study and celebration of Black people as a race, and emphasized the contributions of countless Black men and women to the advancement of human civilization;

Whereas, Since 1976, the commemoration was extended from a week-long event to the entire month of February;

Whereas, Every United States President has officially designated the month of February as Black History Month and other countries around the world, including Canada and the United Kingdom, also devote a month to celebrating Black history;

Whereas, Established by Dr. Carter G. Woodson in 1915, the Association for the Study of African American Life and History (ASALH) strives to promote, research, preserve, interpret, and disseminate information about Black life, history, and culture to the global community;

Whereas, The 2024 theme for Black History Month established by the ASALH is “African Americans and the Arts”;

Whereas, For centuries Western intellectuals denied and minimized the contributions of people of African descent to the arts, even as their artistry in many genres was mimicked and stolen. In truth, the African American experience is woven throughout visual and performing arts, literature, fashion, folklore, language, film, music, architecture, culinary arts and various other forms of cultural expression;

Whereas, African American art is infused with African, Caribbean, and the Black American lived experiences. Artistic and cultural movements such as the New Negro, Black Arts, Black Renaissance, hip-hop, and Afrofuturism, have been led by people of African descent and set the standard for popular

trends around the world;

Whereas, There is an unbroken chain of Black art production from antiquity to the present, from Egypt across Africa, from Europe to the New World. From the African traditions of woven sweetgrass baskets to the birth of Negro spirituals. From the creation of the blues, the foundation for gospel and soul music, to the recently celebrated 50-year anniversary of hip hop. From the Harlem Renaissance of the 1920s and 1930s to the Black Arts Movement of the 1960s;

Whereas, African American artists have historically served as change agents, using their crafts to uplift the race, speak truth to power and inspire a nation. Spirituals, gospel, folk music, hip-hop, and rap have been used to express struggle, hope, and for solidarity in the face of racial oppression. Black artists have used poetry, fiction, short stories, essays, paintings, sculpture, plays, films, and television to counter stereotypes and to imagine a present and future with Black people in it;

Whereas, Black History Month aims to mitigate the persistent and ongoing failure to acknowledge the contributions of Black Culture, Black Inventors, Black Artists, Black Artisans, Black Advocacy Black Leaders, and Black Civic Engagement to American history and society;

Whereas, Black people continually remain optimistic and confident about the path ahead while leading the courageous, yet hard fought fights for the rights, liberties, and freedoms that many marginalized communities are now beneficiaries; and

Whereas, Our democracy's founding ideals were exclusionary when they were written, but Black Americans have continuously fought to make them true; now, therefore, be it

Resolved, That the Governing Board of the Los Angeles Unified School District recognizes February as National Black History Month;

Resolved further, That the Board acknowledges that all people of the United States are beneficiaries of the wealth of history given to all by Black Culture, Black Inventors, Black Artists, Black Artisans, Black Advocacy Black Leaders, and Black Civic Engagement;

Resolved, further, That the Board embeds the study of Black History and Black Arts into the core curriculum of its Ethnic Studies, African American History courses, and African American Literature so that this critical learning lives in the minds of our students beyond the month of February;

Resolved, further, That the Board direct the Superintendent to expand upon the District's existing efforts, such as the Black Student Achievement Plan, to continue to identify strategies and tactics to align resources targeted toward promoting anti-racist educational practices and closing the gap of academic achievement outcomes for Black Students, and, be it finally

Resolved, That the Superintendent will work with educators, librarians, all the schools of the District, and our wider community to recognize and celebrate this month with culturally relevant and appropriate curriculum, programs, ceremonies, and activities that generate in-depth discussion of the complex factual history of the United States and the legacy of Black Americans, including the arts.